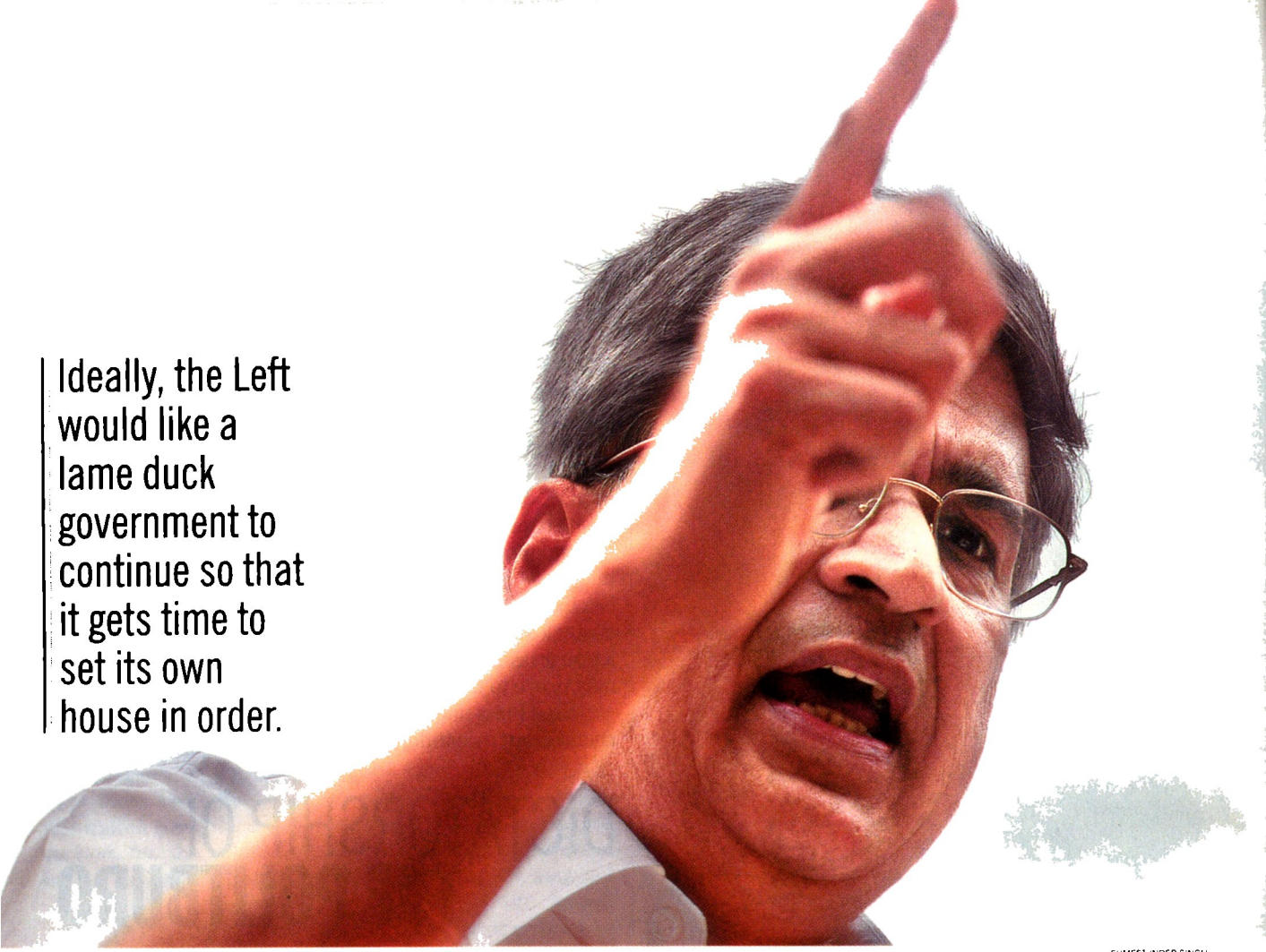




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HARDLINER: A climb-down from the anti-US position will dent Karat's credibility and the image of his party

Lok Sabha, the comrades have controlled Government policies for over three years now. Never in the history of Independent India has the Left been in such a privileged position. Shortening its enviable tenure by a year-and-a-half would be an immense decision. Ideally, the Left would like a lame duck government to continue so that it can set its own house in order in Kerala and West Bengal.

As a hardliner, Karat is unlikely to back a government that has strategically allied with the US. The Left Front's critical outside support to the Congress was in the first place an ill-conceived idea since the two parties share nothing but antipathy for each other. Karat himself believes that coalition governments of ideologically opposed parties do not work. A climb-down from the anti-US position will make a serious dent on his credibility. But blaming Manmohan alone for the crisis would be unfair. The Left Front has failed to articulate its opposition effectively. While it had succeeded in talking down Manmohan on economic reforms through aggressive sustained campaigns, the Left has confused people on foreign policy. "We have been cautioning the Government on the consequences of its association with America. We need to explain more to the people," Bardhan says.

India's middle class, which is reportedly miffed with the Left's stand, is anyway far from its core constituency. Poll managers in CPI(M) feel they can tell voters that they "stopped India's sell-out" to the US by pulling the plug of the Government. While the Left would not be disappointed if it

manages to retain its 59 seats in the Lok Sabha, it would like to capitalise on its anti-Americanism. It is hopeful that it will appeal to Indian Muslims who have been harbouring anti-US sentiments since 9/11. In the next elections, the Left will need to ally with the Third Front. The rise of regional parties and competitive multi-party politics has forced the Indian Left to hold on to its sense of identity. And the only way it can distinguish itself from the rest is by following the dogmatic line.

by Satarupa Bhattacharya

OPPOSE AND BE EXPOSED

BJP seems to have disowned its legacy as India's first right wing party in power that initiated the engagement with the US

Trust Amar Singh to set the cat among the already scattering pigeons. The recent crisis has brought the SP leader back in the mainstream. "If BJP does not move a no-confidence motion against this Government, UNPA will," he says. The NDA is still to take a stand on whether to move a motion of no confidence. "As Napoleon said, when your enemy is intent on committing suicide, why rush in and spoil the party," says a BJP general secretary, chuckling that "the Left has finally got it right". But are they opposing the deal merely for the sake of opposition? BJP seems to be